

The spirit of Christmas

The personification of Christmas magic, Father Christmas represents a fusion of modern commercialism and Christian belief. He originated in medieval Europe, where the 3rd-century St. Nicholas (bishop, gift bringer, and patron of children) gradually became a mythical figure associated with Christmas. St. Nicholas was believed to have miraculous attributes, including the power to travel across the sky, delivering gifts to children in many places at once.

In Northern Europe, less saintly versions of St. Nicholas, such as Britain's Father Christmas and the Germanic Christkind, emerged during the Protestant Reformation in the 16th century. These figures often had supernatural assistants (most famously elves), as well as the ability to know whether children had been good or bad.

The modern Father Christmas—or Santa Claus, from the Dutch Sinter Klauss (short for Sint Nikolaas)—was created in 19th-century America. In the 1823 poem *'Twas The Night Before Christmas*, “St. Nick” has eight flying reindeer and can magically descend and ascend a chimney. Commercial advertising, notably from Coca-Cola in the 20th century, cemented this version of Father Christmas in popular culture. Taking different forms around the world today, he still delights children who long to believe in his magic.

“... Laying his finger aside
of his nose, And giving a nod,
up the chimney he rose ...”

CLEMENT C. MOORE, “’Twas The Night Before Christmas,” 1823

